Time clauses and sequence words

Understand it

Time words organize history passages, processes and lectures. They also control tenses: after when, as soon as, until, before, after and once, use a present tense to talk about the future.

In Listening Section 4, the lecturer uses sequence words to move between parts. Write them in your notes: they help you follow the order of the answers.

The rules

- Time words: before, after, when, while, as soon as, until, by the time, once, since, already, yet, no longer, eventually.
- After a time word, use a present tense for the future: When the lecture ends, we will ask questions. (not will end)
- Present perfect: since and for. He has lived here since 2010 / for ten years.
- Sequence: first, second, next, then, after that, finally, at the same time.

All the words and forms you need

Before / after	before · after · prior to · following · previously · subsequently · later
At the same time	while · as · meanwhile · simultaneously · at the same time
Point in time	when · once · as soon as · the moment · by the time · by then
Duration	for · since · during · throughout · until · till · so far · up to now
Order	first · initially · to begin with · then · next · after that · eventually · finally · in the end
Change	still · already · yet · no longer · any more · from then on

Where you use it

Reading: Time words show the order of events in history and science texts.

Listening: Section 4 lectures use sequence words to organize. Write the order, not every word.

Writing: Processes use first, then, finally. Maps use previously, now.

Speaking: Part 2 stories: At first, then, in the end.

More examples

- As soon as the water boils, the tea is added.
- Prior to 1990, the town had no airport.

- By the time the rescue team arrived, the storm had passed.
- The factory has been closed since 2015.
- Initially the plan failed, but eventually it succeeded.
- People no longer write letters by hand.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ When I will arrive, I will call.	✓ When I arrive, I will call.
✗ I live here since 2015.	✓ I have lived here since 2015.
✗ He no longer is here.	✓ He is no longer here.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What will you do as soon as you finish the exam?
2. How long have you lived in your home?
3. What did you do before you started learning English?
4. What things do people no longer do in your country?

Writing practice

Write a 5-sentence history of your town using prior to, since, by the time, eventually and no longer.

Practice

1. Complete: As soon as she ___ (finish), she will call.

2. Complete: They have worked here ___ 2018. (since / for)

3. Complete: She has studied ___ three years. (since / for)

4. Order: 'finally, first, then' (1-2-3)

5. Correct: Until the rain will stop, we wait.

6. Choose: He (already / yet) finished.

Answers

1. finishes
2. since
3. for
4. first, then, finally
5. Until the rain stops, we will wait.
6. has already finished